

ON TO THE HIGHLANDS

ARBOREAL LUXURY
Top, the Woodpecker Tree House in the Pepper Trail estate; below, the bedroom in the tree house

My ride to Wayanad curves north-eastward into forested hills, where hairpin bends and misty slopes make for a scenic drive. The sun hangs low as our wheels roll into the lush haven that is Pepper Trail estate. Set deep within a former colonial plantation, Pepper Trail feels less like a resort and more like a secret camp.

Over breakfast in the main pavilion, I meet owner Anand Jayan, whose grandfather P. Balram Kurup bought the 200-acre coffee, spice and tea estate in 1932 from a Scotsman. Anand's is the hand behind the retreat's thoughtful, sustainable and immersive soul. Perfectly balancing the wilderness experience with elevated comfort, the 150-year-old two-suite colonial bungalow with its back-to-roots aesthetic delivers on its promise of nostalgia. Two treehouses, built 40 feet high on sturdy jackfruit trees, feel like something out of a fantasy fiction film, and the rooms themselves, while arboreal, make no compromises on either space or the high-end feel. For the more down-to-earth, the villas boast grande-sized quarters, a front garden, and a forest-facing private infinity pool.



At Wayanad, there's something for everyone: its wildlife sanctuary has bird-watching and safaris, while Soochipara and Meenmutty waterfalls are magnificent after the rains. Further west, Banasura Sagar Dam, Asia's largest earthen dam, tempts with boat rides and viewpoints. Thrill-seekers can hike to Chembra Peak, climb up to the Edakkal Caves where stone-age petroglyphs line the walls, or go zip-lining. History buffs will find the Wayanad Heritage Museum an unassuming gem while retail-hounds can peruse the local markets at Sultan Bathery just 20 minutes away.

It's hard to imagine a more perfect getaway, but the forces of nature tend to follow a different policy from "customer is king". North Kerala tourism faced a trifecta of setbacks with Covid-19, the 2024 floods and recent landslides. Though the tragedy struck a limited geography, the entire district's tourism bookings collapsed. Since then, however, recovery efforts spell hope. Altaf Chapri, who runs Neeleshwar Hermitage, my next and final stop in North Kerala, is enthused by the boom: "Southern Kerala has overgrown. Concrete, crowds... but here, the beaches still breathe. Between on-season swimming, dolphins and migratory birds in the winter, backwaters and treks, or restorative wellness therapies—northern Kerala has it all," he adds.